



MALI

Capital city: Bamako
Area: 478,764 sq miles (1,240,000 sq km)
Population: 13,000,000
Official language: French
Major religions: Muslim 80%, traditional beliefs 18%, Christian 1%, other 1%
Government: Democracy
Currency: CFA franc
Adult literacy rate: 26%
Life expectancy: 41 years
People per doctor: 10,000
Televisions: 12 per 1,000 people

MALI

THE LANDSCAPE OF MALI ranges from the vast desert plains of the Sahara in the north, through the semidesert Sahel region in the center, to wetter savanna in the south. A thin belt of fertile land stretches on each side of the Niger and Senegal rivers. The country gets its name from the great Muslim empire of the Malinke people, which flourished in this region in the 13th and 14th centuries. Today, Mali is a poor country where most people make their living from farming or herding cattle.

The Niger River at Bamako, in southern Mali



THE NIGER

The Niger River is the lifeline of Mali, flowing through the country from west to east before turning south to pour into the Atlantic Ocean. Most people in the country live along its banks, using the river as a source of water and food and as a main means of transportation. The capital of Mali, Bamako, on the upper reaches of the river, is a major port, shipping cement and fuel downriver, and receiving rice and peanuts for export in exchange.

RICE GROWING

In the center of Mali, the Niger River splits into several branches. This area is called the river's inland delta, and is one of the most fertile regions of the country. Here, as the river begins to flood, farmers plant a special "floating" rice that grows up to 12 in (30 cm) a day to keep pace with the rising waters. When the crop is ready, the farmers harvest it from boats.



MOSQUES

Islam arrived in Mali with merchants traveling across the Sahara from the Arab north. By the 13th century, Mali was entirely Muslim, with mosques built in most towns. Mosques like this one at Mopti are constructed of clay around a wooden framework that sticks out in turrets above the roof. The wooden beams jutting out through the walls allow villagers to climb all over the building to carry out its annual repairs.



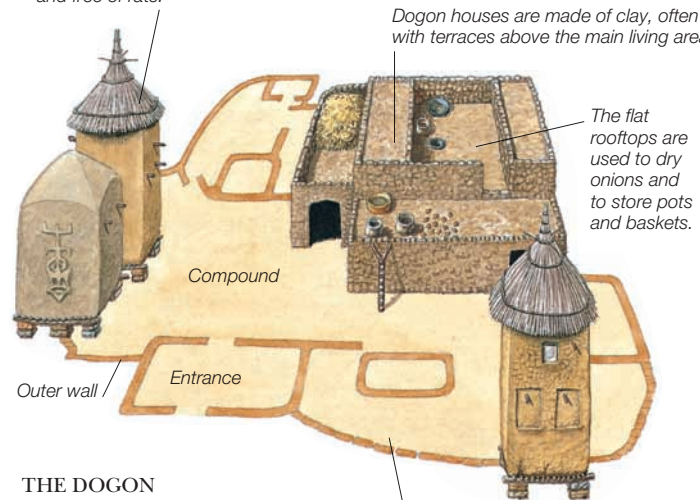
TIMBUKTU

Founded by Tuareg nomads in 1100, Timbuktu became one of the most famous cities in Africa. Because of its position on the trade route across the Sahara, it soon developed into a major town.

Arab traders from the north brought salt, cloth, and horses to exchange for gold and slaves from the south. By 1400, Timbuktu had become a major center of Islamic learning.

Granaries are built of thick clay to keep the grain cool and free of rats.

Dogon houses are made of clay, often with terraces above the main living area.



The flat rooftops are used to dry onions and to store pots and baskets.

The Dogon live in walled compounds built on steep hillsides for protection against attack from their enemies.

THE DOGON

South of Timbuktu, the flat river plain gives way to sandstone cliffs surrounding the Bandiagara plateau. Living in the cliffs are the Dogon people, who first settled in the area in the 1500s. The Dogon worship their own gods, and have many legends about the creation of the world. Because of the harsh conditions in which they live, the Dogon are expert farmers, using every available strip of land to grow crops of rice, millet, and corn.

Find out more

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